

Understanding Russia's War in Ukraine: Identity, Threat Perception and Strategic Judgement

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“I cannot forecast to you the action of Russia. It is a riddle wrapped in a mystery inside an enigma; but perhaps there is a key. That key is Russian national interest.” – Winston Churchill (1939).

Abstract:

The Russo-Ukrainian War has led to divergent interpretations and fierce debate in discussions surrounding Russian foreign policy, reflecting the complexities inherent in understanding the motivations and dynamics behind this pivotal geopolitical event. Departing from conventional realist explanations, this research introduces the concept of ontological security to delve into the psychological and identity-based motivations behind Russia’s invasion of Ukraine. Through critical discourse analysis, the thesis explores how Russian leadership came to consider the image of a Westernised Ukraine as an existential threat to its ontological security. By employing a constructivist framework to critique the prevalent structural realist account, the thesis seeks to address the gap between public perception and scholarly analysis.

Key Words: Russia, Ukraine, Ontological Security, Identity, Constructivism, Structural Realism.

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1. Introduction

Russia's invasion of Ukraine stands as a compelling and pertinent case study that captivates scholars and practitioners in the field of international relations (IR). Apart from its direct contemporary significance, with the war's widespread presence in global headlines and public discourse, the invasion poses thought-provoking theoretical questions, urging scholars to delve into the intricacies of interstate behaviour. In contrast to public opinion and certain world leaders pronouncing the Kremlin as operating in "another world",¹ scholars usually emphasise the calculated rationality of Russian foreign policy (RFP). Accordingly, the academic arena remains awash with continuous deliberations as scholars grapple to come to terms with the motivations behind Russia's invasion of Ukraine. Despite extensive scholarly pursuits, the discourse often revolves around perspectives from the structuralist realist school, which, while offering some valuable insights, fall short of fully elucidating the profound dynamics underlying Russia's actions.

It is against this backdrop that this thesis introduces the concept of ontological security. By shifting the focus to the realms of psychological and identity-based factors, this research aims to uncover a more nuanced understanding of Russia's actions towards Ukraine. Implicit in this inquiry lies a broader curiosity: how can we discern Russia's role as a global actor in the complex dynamics of the contemporary international sphere? Furthermore, how might the theory of ontological security provide insights into the intricacies of interstate behaviour beyond the scope of conventional realist paradigms? These fundamental inquiries serve as the guiding force behind the present thesis, underscoring its overarching objective: to offer a more holistic and comprehensive understanding of the Russo-Ukrainian War, its drivers, and the intricate interplay of identities and interests that shape the international landscape.

¹ A phrase famously employed by German Chancellor Angela Merkel while recounting her dialogue with Russian President Vladimir Putin to United States President Barack Obama, in the aftermath of the 2014 Russian annexation of Crimea (Baker 2014).

2. Theoretical Framework

Grounded within the constructivist paradigm of IR, this thesis is built on the premise that RFP actions are intricately moulded by the social identification of both itself and other pertinent actors. The ascent of constructivist theory has had a major influence on the analysis of RFP. However, constructivist insights still remain somewhat overlooked in both scholarly and public inquiry. Notably, realist accounts cast a sizable shadow over conventional discussions concerning RFP, often pushing aside considerations beyond the confines of the paradigm.

In this context, this thesis harnesses constructivist theory to critically scrutinise the legitimacy and applicability of mainstream realist theory in comprehending the Russo-Ukrainian War. Consequently, the forthcoming chapter delineates the theoretical bedrock upon which this thesis rests, elucidating both constructivist theory and the intricate concept of ontological security. Through this exploration, it will become evident how these theoretical standpoints can furnish a more holistic comprehension of the Russo-Ukrainian War and RFP more broadly, transcending the limitations imposed by prevailing realist accounts.

2.1 The Limitations of Structural Realist Theory in RFP

IR theories principally seek to explain how states behave. Consequently, the deliberation over what factors influence state behaviour has been ongoing since the discipline's inception. Kenneth Waltz (1979), in his pursuit of a parsimonious theory of IR, argues that interstate behaviour must be understood through the context of a system. His prominent structural realist theory marginalises the unit (state) level of analysis, instead focussing on (international) system-level influences, such as the distribution of power, to explain and predict geopolitical trends. It is argued that while states vary according to their material power, they are rational actors who are all similarly respondent to the incentives and pressures of the anarchic international system. This is because physical security is always a state's first interest for "only if survival is assured can states safely seek such other goals as tranquillity, profit and power" (Waltz 1979, 126). By treating national interest as a pre-determined variable, structural realists tend to treat social factors like culture and identity as purely sub-systemic phenomena, distinct to the conflicts, war and insecurity that occupies the international. While this provides a general framework that can be useful in analysing broader geopolitical trends, it fails to provide a

nuanced appreciation for the complexity of foreign policy change. Waltz (1979, 121), makes this limitation clear:

“The theory does not explain why state X made a certain move last Tuesday. To expect it to do so would be like expecting the theory of universal gravitation to explain the wayward path of a falling leaf. A theory at one level of generality cannot answer questions about matters at a different level of generality.”

Therefore, while structural realism undoubtedly contributes valuable insights into policy continuity, its intrinsic emphasis on broader, materialist factors restrains its capacity to explain the intricate underpinnings of specific RFP. Yet, as our forthcoming exploration in the literature review will reveal, numerous commentators leverage structural realism as a tool for dissecting the intricate dynamics underlying Russia’s invasion of Ukraine (Smith and Dawson 2017, 181). Unfortunately, this approach can yield a fragmented and restricted comprehension of the war’s complexities, potentially leading to misguided influence on foreign policy practitioners and public perceptions.

However, it is essential to recognise that realism is a broad church, and the principles of structural realism, despite its prevalence in practice and public discourses, offer only a partial view within this spectrum. Neoclassical realism, for instance, acknowledges the potential for domestic factors to interact with and even modify the ultimate impact of international dynamics (Rose 1998, 146-154). While neoclassical approaches represent an advancement over structural realism in RFP analysis, their primary focus on systemic-level variables still restricts in-depth exploration into the complex social dynamics that drove Russia to invade. Hence, this thesis turns its focus to constructivism, which delves deeply into the intricate interplay of identity, meaning, and social interactions.

2.2 Constructivism

The constructivist paradigm emphasises the profound social nature of IR. Through infusing ideational and normative factors into IR, constructivism challenges the conventional realist depiction of the international system as a mere configuration of material forces. According to Alexander Wendt (1999, 139), “the task of structural theorising ultimately must be to show how the elements of the system fit together into some kind of whole”, dismissing the Waltzian

jettison of ideational and normative factors. The constructivist approach stresses that while these factors might be conceptually abstract, they too constitute IR.

Central to constructivism is the recognition that state behaviour is not solely driven by objective power calculations or material incentives. Instead, an interplay of ideas, interpretations and interests steer actions. States seldom develop enduring and readily discernible declarations of their fundamental interests. Instead, their interests remain in a constant state of flux as diverse schools of thought respond to varying domestic and international dynamics (Tsygankov 2016, 16). Wendt acknowledges the intricacy of this, recognising that “many situations call up several identities that may point in different directions” (1999, 230). This perspective challenges the deterministic tendencies of rationalist and materialist paradigms, offering a nuanced comprehension of the intricate dynamics underlying international interactions and foreign policymaking.

The constructivist focus on language underscores the interplay between identity and discourse within a state’s foreign policy. As Jutta Weldes (1996, 280) proposes, comprehending identity necessitates understanding the discursive representations behind it. This perspective affirms that identity is not a static entity detached from foreign policy; rather, as Lene Hansen (2006, 6) outlines, policies pivot on representations of the challenges they seek to address. This notion recognises the nuanced nature of these variables, their non-amenability to scientific and material quantification, necessitating a deep understanding of their evolving dynamics.

Constructivism does not negate realist insights; rather, it refines and broadens them. While material factors maintain relevance, their meanings emerge relationally through shared interpretations by actors. Wendt (1995, 73) encapsulates this notion, asserting that “material capabilities as such explain nothing; their effects presuppose structures of shared knowledge, which vary and which are not reducible to capabilities.” In this light, material factors are not exogenous to social interactions; they derive meaning from relational contexts and interpretations.

Consider the concept of national security. Within realism, national security is traditionally conceptualised as a fundamental and pre-existing factor– “a property that states either possess or do not possess, often presented in quantifiable dimensions of material power” (Fierke 2015, 24). Constructivism redefines this, asserting that security is a fluid product of social

interactions, negotiations, and shared understandings among states. Security is, therefore, not a fixed and measurable entity; it materialises through interpretations and anticipations of potential threats. Whilst complex, grasping this dynamic and subjective dimension is crucial for a more comprehensive understanding of the interest and action of a specific state.

2.3 Ontological Security

In its reconceptualization of security, constructivism can transcend traditional security paradigms to introduce the notion of ontological security. This concept pertains to the “security of being”, extending beyond mere physical survival (Steele 2008, 51). In contrast to the conventional focus on material strength and physical security, ontological security intertwines social identity, historical interactions, and individual perceptions, thus offering a fresh lens to understand interstate behaviour. To gain a clearer understanding of the conceptual distinction between ontological and traditional (physical) security, please see Table 1 below.

	Traditional Security	Ontological Security
Security as...	Survival	Being
Agent “structured” by...	Fear (in the face of threat)	Anxiety (uncomfortable disconnect with Self)
Outcome of incorrect decision in the face of challenge	Physical harm	Shame
Measurement of outcome	Change in material capabilities; deaths; damage	Difference between biographical narrative and actual behaviour; discursive remorse
Structural change	Change in distribution of power	Routinization critical situations; change in self-identity; change in agent routine

Table 1. Two Conceptions of Security (Steele 2008, 52).

The concept of ontological security is rooted in human psychology, focussing on the security of an individual’s identity. The term was first coined by psychiatrist R. D. Liang (1960), who differentiated between ontologically secure and insecure schizophrenic patients based on the stability of their autonomy and identity (41). Building on Liang’s work, sociologist Anthony Giddens (1991) incorporated ontological security into his theory of modernity and self-identity.

Giddens argues that individuals establish routines - a continuity of coherent and self-referential interactions - in order to cultivate a sense of identity (37-38). The “reflexive project of the self...consists in the sustaining of coherent yet continually revised biographical narratives”, emphasising the importance of stable yet adaptable identity narratives for individuals. This notion underscores the significance of ontological security in understanding how individuals maintain a sense of self amidst ever-changing circumstances and challenges.

Jennifer Mitzen (2006) and Brent Steele (2008) extended the application of ontological security to the realm of IR, proposing that states, composed of individuals, also seek this sense of security. When seeking to uphold ontological security, a state’s foremost concern shifts towards preserving its identity, a facet often overshadowed by the predominant emphasis on physical security in traditional IR theory. According to Mitzen (2006), states actively work to fortify their identities through the establishment of habitual interactions with significant Other(s). This approach imbues states with a sense of agency, facilitating decision-making grounded in predictable outcomes. Conversely, actions from external entities that disrupt these routines can trigger ontological insecurity, prompting the state to recalibrate its interactions to realign with its perceived self-concept.

Steele (2008) further elaborates on this concept by suggesting that a state’s identity evolves through a the Giddensian “biographical narrative”. This concept is intricately interwoven with the historical narratives and collective memory of the state. As Anthony Smith (1996, 383) suggests, identity cannot exist without a foundation of memory and historical comprehension. This sentiment is echoed by Maurice Halbwachs (1980, 86), a pioneering scholar in collective memory, who posits that each group develops a narrative of its past, emphasising its distinctive identity in relation to other groups. These constructed narratives endow the group with a sense of origin, evolution, and self-recognition over time. In moments of crisis, certain narratives arise to provide a cognitive bridge between radical policy changes (Subotić 2016). These narratives play a crucial role in offering a sense of biographical continuity, routine, familiarity, and calm, thus aiding the collective psyche during periods of upheaval. In essence, the biographical narrative encompasses the collective means by which states introspectively attribute the origins of their actions (Steele 2008, 55), serving as the bedrock upon which they decipher their positioning within the social contexts they inhabit (Steele 2008, 71). Understanding the significance of these narratives and their role in providing continuity and a

sense of identity is pivotal for comprehending a state's foreign policy behaviour. They form the lens through which a state interprets its interactions with other actors and the world at large, ultimately guiding its responses to challenges and opportunities on the global stage.

As a consequence, ontological insecurity can arise from internal shifts within the national identity, stemming from transformative potentials not confined solely to the interactions between the Self and the Other(s), but also within the internal discourse (Steele 2008, 32). In essence, a state enters a state of ontological insecurity when its actions diverge from internal changes in its identity, compelling it to recalibrate its interactions with other actors. Mitzen (2006, 342) argues that the pursuit of ontological security is so strong that states may prioritise it over physical security, leading them to become “attached to conflict”, even if it is harmful or self-defeating.

The concept of ontological security helps to shed light on the perceived irrationality of Russia's invasion of Ukraine. While the Russo-Ukrainian War has been a disaster for Russia from a material standpoint, with a significant loss of life, resources and risk to physical security,² the lens of ontological security suggests that Russia's actions in Ukraine reflect a rational pursuit of its ontological identity rather than mere pursuit of physical security. For instance, Smith and Dawson (2017, 185) argue that the West's “imposition of its social identity on Ukraine” poses not only “a tangible security threat to Russia, but also a deeper ontological threat”, challenging Russia's sense of self-worth and identity vis-à-vis the West. However, Smith and Dawson's analysis primarily aligns with classical realism and neoclassical realism, limiting in-depth exploration of the foundations of Russia's ontological security. Consequently, this thesis aims to conduct a more comprehensive inquiry. Its objective is to offer robust constructivist insights into the Russo-Ukrainian War, thus providing a more nuanced and intricate understanding of the interplay between Russia's ontological security and RFP.

2.4 Conclusion

In conclusion, the theoretical framework presented here establishes a critical foundation for understanding the intricate dynamics of RFP in the context of the Russo-Ukrainian War.

² For literature on the material losses of Russia's invasion of Ukraine, see: Jones 2022; The Economist 2022; The Bank of Russia 2022; Demertzis et al. 2022; Nelson 2022.

Delving into the constructivist paradigm, the framework recognises that states are not predictable actors driven solely by material interests, but rather intricate entities influenced by the interplay of identity, ontological security, and narratives. This framework transcends the limitations of structural realism and highlights the significance of ideational factors that often evade conventional theoretical lenses. The subsequent literature review explores diverse viewpoints on the Russo-Ukrainian War, aiming to unravel how various scholars interpret Russia's actions. This synthesis of perspectives aims to unveil the layered motivations and interpretations contributing to the "enigma" of Russian state action and interest.

3. Literature Review

With the historical prominence of realist understandings of state security and interests, the realm of IR has traditionally focused on factors that, when examined in isolation, leave significant gaps in our understanding of RFP. Despite the emergence of constructivist perspectives, conventional theories of interstate behaviour, such as structural realism, continue to dominate mainstream analyses and interpretations.

The literature review presented here will compare structural realist and constructivist literature relevant to the Russo-Ukrainian War. While not exhaustive, it outlines challenges to the structural realist account of the war before delving into relevant constructivist perspectives.

3.1 The Structural Realist Account of the Russo-Ukrainian War

The structural realist perspective on the Russo-Ukrainian war, championed by John J. Mearsheimer, has drawn attention for its perceived cogency (Chotiner 2022; Rachman 2023). Mearsheimer (2014, 77) attributes the crisis to North Atlantic Treaty Organisation (NATO) expansion, European Union (EU) enlargement, and Western-backed pro-democracy efforts in Ukraine. It is argued that these posed a direct threat to Russia and its “core strategic interests” (Mearsheimer 2014, 86). Writing after the 2022 invasion, Mearsheimer (2022, 12) stressed that this proved to be an “existential threat” to Russia from a geopolitical standpoint. However, his analysis inadvertently introduces ideational elements, which contradicts his structural realist stance.

Mearsheimer’s (2001) brand of offensive structural realism emphasises power dynamics and rational state behaviour but overlooks ideational and sub-systemic complexities, akin to Waltzian theory. However, Mearsheimer’s assertions that “liberal delusions” in the West and pro-democracy movements influenced the war implies the involvement of normative and ideological factors, contrary to his theory’s tenets (2014, 77). This incongruity weakens his claim that power pursuit alone explains complex geopolitical events.

Whilst Mearsheimer’s blame of the West is perhaps the most pronounced, other scholars also emphasise NATO’s expansion as a material threat to Russia (Lukin 2014; Charap and Colton 2017; Taylor 2018). It is often suggested that Russia was left with no other choice but to invade

Ukraine and therefore, the decision was a rational, realist response to system-level pressures. However, this perspective arguably amplifies the limited military threat NATO members posed. As Richard Ned Lebow (2022, 130) argues, prior Russia's annexation of Crimea in 2014, new NATO members' "military forces were weak and trained for defensive strategies. There was no Western intention to incorporate Ukraine into NATO. NATO as a whole, and Germany especially, had reduced defence spending. The threat posed by the West was political, economic, and cultural, not strategic."

The Western monolithic expansion narrative also fails to consider concessions and attempts at cooperation made by NATO (NATO 2022), which contests the claim of aggressive expansion. As Mueller (2021, 255) highlights, a number of treaties and political offerings were signed amid concerns of aggravating Moscow – such as the NATO-Russia Founding Act, the Treaty on Conventional Armed Forces in Europe, and the acceptance of Russia into the Group of 8 (G8).

A broader perspective reveals that Russia's response was not uniform among regional states. Some embraced NATO expansion, indicating that ideational and normative factors played a role in shaping Russia's threat perception. Clunan (2018, 46) argues that the liberal democratic foundations of Western expansion, incongruent with Russia's command-style politics and economy, contributed to these dynamics. Zwolski (2016) delves deeper into the issue, emphasising how Russia's failed integration with the West following the disintegration of the Soviet Union laid the groundwork for its reaction. The exclusion of Russia from the European security architecture, while newly independent states were welcomed, fostered a sense of isolation and alienation. This intricate web of interactions highlights that states do not respond uniformly to international pressures; their character, identity and history profoundly shape their foreign policymaking (Kirshner 2022, 181-205). An exploration of sub-systemic factors can reveal the complexity of the Russo-Ukrainian War, a complexity that structural realism struggles to fully capture.

3.2 Constructivist Studies of RFP and the Russo-Ukrainian War

Recognising the significance of domestic identity debates in understanding RFP, constructivist scholars aim to pinpoint conflicting identity paradigms, discourses, or ideological approaches and to elucidate their evolution across time (Hopf 2002; Light 2003; Lo 2003; Clunan 2009;

Tsygankov 2016). It is commonly argued that the complexities stemming from the end of the Cold War did not merely trigger a geopolitical crisis, but also an identity crisis within Russia. The period saw Russia's geographical, political, ideological, and cultural dimensions blur into ambiguity (Selezneva 2003; Lo 2003; Zevelev 2016). This gave rise to a tug-of-war between two ideological schools: one advocating for a Westernised, liberal Russia, and the other championing a distinctive, Greater Russian Statehood (Selezneva 2003; Tsygankov 2016).

This ideological clash traces its origins back to the great intellectual debates of the nineteenth century between the Slavophiles and Westernisers (Malinova 2014; Zevelev 2016). The Slavophiles championed the uniqueness of Russian civilisation while resisting the rationalism and uniformity of Western civilisation. It is argued that this historical backdrop, while evolving over time, has left enduring sentiments. Even amidst the post-Soviet transformation, Bobo Lo (2003, 13) argues that the belief that "Russia had been, was and would always be a great power, and a transcontinental entity" endured. Moreover, Walter Laqueur (2014, 77) highlights how the notion of "anti-Westernism" remains a consistent undercurrent in Russian identity, taking on various forms throughout history. This sentiment has seemingly "crystallised" during Vladimir Putin's presidency (Roberts 2017, 4), as scholars like Igor Zevelev (2016, 1) note a reorientation of RFP to align with a distinct Russian identity – one that anchors Russia's global role in its unique history, size, and autonomous civilisational identity.

Within this context, it is often argued that Russia's perceptions and interactions with the West, their significant Other, have contributed to developments in Russia's identity and foreign policy (Morozov 2015). Russia's perception of whether or not the West denies or accepts their identity as a unique great power is often said to drive RFP. Tsygankov (2016, 1), for instance, argues that what "often determines Moscow's foreign policy choices is whether or not the West's international actions are perceived by Russian officials as accepting Russia as an equal and legitimate member of the world." This observation is evident in the work of Liah Greenfield (1990) and Olga Malinova (2014), who highlight the emotions of status insecurity and *ressentiment* in shaping Russian national identity and RFP throughout history.

Various scholarship, therefore, reads Russia's invasion of Ukraine via interpretations of Russia's identity. For instance, Taras Kuzio (2022) argues the invasion's roots can be found in a revival of both Tsarist and Soviet-era discourses that project an image of a pan-Russian civilisation that decries the existence of Ukrainian sovereignty. Likewise, Jane Burbank (2022)

argues that the Russian state discourse has been nurturing “plans to reunite Ukraine and other post-Soviet states into a trans-continental superpower [...] A revitalised theory of Eurasian empire informs Mr Putin’s every move.” Therefore, there are many indications that Russia’s actions towards Ukraine are underpinned by powerful non-material factors. Whilst Russia’s invasion of Ukraine may have been influenced by the perceived material and physical threat that NATO produced, this claim is somewhat exaggerated. Other scholars perceive Russia’s domination over Ukraine as a *sine qua non* for Russia’s great power status and thus underscore the ideational, historical and ideological factors that led Russia to invade.

3.3 Conclusion

This chapter has critically examined the perspectives of structural realism and constructivism in relation to the Russo-Ukrainian War. These perspectives have offered distinct insights into the role of material power dynamics and identity-driven influences in shaping RFP. Importantly, this review has also presented literature that challenges the structural realist account, illuminating the limitations inherent in a theory solely anchored in materialist assumptions.

Nevertheless, the Russo-Ukrainian War stands as a compelling case study that, due to its recent occurrence, remains ripe for further exploration. By delving into the interplay between ontological security, national identity, and foreign policy, this study aims to uncover the complex interactions and influences among these factors. This not only contributes to a more nuanced comprehension of the intricacies within the war but also addresses a notable gap in the prevailing structural realist perspective. Moreover, by utilising the war as a focal point to examine ontological security, this thesis seeks to underscore the relevance of ontological security in the contemporary international landscape. The ensuing section will provide a more detailed delineation of the research design and methodology employed in this endeavour.

4. Research Design and Methodology

The research design of this thesis embraces critical discourse analysis (CDA), firmly rooted in constructivist theory. Within CDA, language is viewed as a social practice, with profound emphasis placed on context (Fairclough and Wodak, 1997). Originating from Michel Foucault's work (1972), CDA perceives discourses as socially constructed systems that generate knowledge and significance within specific historical contexts. Central to CDA is its exploration of how certain social systems are endowed with importance, enriching our understanding of the surrounding world. Fairclough (1995, 23) further advocates CDA's application as an "analytical framework for studying connections between language, power, and ideology." Thus, the methodological approach facilitates an in-depth exploration of the complex relationships between linguistic constructs, power dynamics, and socio-political contexts that shape discursive strategies.

In this sense, CDA extends the role of texts beyond mere language comprehension. They function as conduits for crafting narratives, imagery, and power structures, deeply influencing how individuals perceive and interpret information. One such example of this is in William A. Gamson and Andre Modigliani's 1989 paper, titled "Media Discourse and Public Opinion on Nuclear Power: A Constructivist Approach." Here, the authors explore the US media discourse on nuclear power, arguing that it is "an essential context for understanding the formation of public opinion on nuclear power" (1). Thus, the manipulation of language, whether deliberate or not, can foster the dissemination of particular narratives and contribute to the establishment of power dynamics within discourses and wider public audiences. Discerning the subtleties of word choice and textual arrangement becomes pivotal in comprehending how meanings emerge, identities solidify, and authority resonates within communicative contexts.

While CDA can encompass both qualitative and quantitative approaches, this thesis exclusively adopts a qualitative CDA methodology. CDA offers profound insights into the construction and propagation of Russia's identity construction in relation to Ukraine. By detecting patterns and trends in the Russian state discourse concerning the Russo-Ukrainian War, this thesis will uncover how the portrayal of a Westernised Ukraine was perceived as a threat to Russia's ontological security, ultimately leading to conflict.

The methodology of this study draws of Fairclough’s “three-dimensional” framework for conducting CDA. This model integrates different layers of analysis which encompass phonological, grammatical, lexical, and vocabularic elements (Fairclough, 1995). CDA also leverages language and grammar theories, which spotlight the ideational, interpersonal, and textual functions of language. Fairclough envisions CDA as a multi-dimensional construct that facilitates three distinctive avenues of analysis: exploration of language, encompassing an examination of word choice and text sequencing; the assessment of discourse practices, which includes both text production and interpretation; and the analysis of discursive events as social practices, operating “in the immediate situation, in the wider institution or organisation, and at the societal level” (Fairclough 1995, 97). For a visual representation of the CDA framework adopted by this study, refer to Figure 1, which illustrates Fairclough’s three-dimensional model.

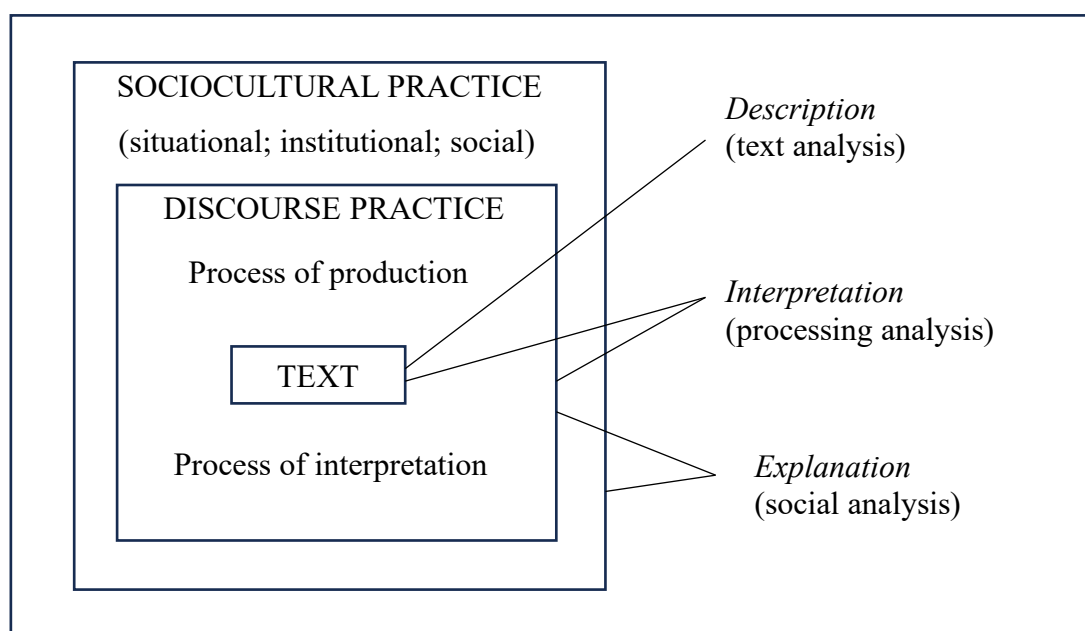


Figure 1. Fairclough’s three-dimensional framework for CDA.

4.2 Source Selection and Potential Limitations

It is essential to acknowledge the limitation of language in this research. As the researcher does not read Russian, the primary sources selected will be official translations. They will include official speeches and public statements from President Vladimir Putin, and on occasion, foreign minister Sergei Lavrov. Utilising primary sources from high-ranking officials provides a unique and invaluable perspective on the Russian state’s official positions and intentions. These

sources are highly authoritative, offering direct insights into the policy formulation process, foreign policy objectives, and national interests of Russia. By drawing directly from statements made by these officials, the analysis gains a more accurate understanding of how the Russian leadership perceives and portrays key events and actors. This approach reduces the potential for misinterpretation or distortion often associated with secondary sources. Additionally, the use of these primary sources enhances the credibility and rigor of the research, as it ensures that arguments and conclusions are firmly rooted in the words and actions of the policymakers themselves. Occasionally, secondary sources, such as academic articles, will be utilised in the introductions and conclusions to enrich the analysis contextually and interpretively.

In CDA, the researcher's subjectivity can impact the findings (Hopf 2002, 25), highlighting the importance of cross-referencing themes and discursive strategies with multiple sources. To achieve this, a systematic coding method will be employed to identify and categorise each theme. Within each primary source, relevant quotations pertaining to specific narratives will be carefully highlighted and coded under their corresponding theme. The resultant analysis will then be subdivided under each identified theme, ensuring that each primary source is cross-checked and corroborated by several others from the sample.

The selection of primary sources may have an impact on the analysis and interpretation, requiring an extended date range to ensure a representative sample. Given the focus on the discourse concerning the Russo-Ukrainian War, the time frame for analysis will be from 2012 to 2023. In 2012, Putin returned for his third term as the president of Russia, succeeding Dmitry Medvedev, who was considered a more conciliatory leader. Putin's third term marked a shift in Russian state discourse, demonstrating a renewed emphasis on Russia's historical identity, which influenced their approach towards Ukraine (Zevelev 2016). For instance, this shift followed developments in 2010, a year that could be seen as a high-water mark for Russo-Ukrainian relations, when Viktor Yanukovich was elected president of Ukraine and signed the Kharkiv Pact, extending the lease of Russia's Black Sea naval fleet in the port of Sevastopol. During Putin's third term, however, the state discourse, amidst a fast-changing geopolitical reality, evolved to reflect a more assertive foreign policy stance towards Ukraine's affairs. Therefore, analysing the state discourse from 2012 to 2023 provides a sufficient scope to examine how the relationship changed and came to threaten Russia's ontological security.

4.3 Conclusion

In conclusion, the methodology and theoretical framework outlined in this section provides a robust foundation for the subsequent research and analysis. Through a CDA methodology rooted in constructivist theory, the study seeks to unravel the intricate interplay between language, identity, and power within the context of Russia's ontological security concerning the Russo-Ukrainian War. The selected timeframe, spanning from 2012 to 2023, encapsulates pivotal developments that transformed the landscape of Russo-Ukrainian relations and influenced Russia's evolving state discourse. This temporal scope offers a lens through which to investigate the dynamic shifts and nuanced narratives that contributed to the emergence of a Ukraine that ostensibly challenged Russia's ontological security. With this methodological groundwork laid, the subsequent sections delve into the empirical analysis of Russia's state discourse and the subsequent impacts on the broader geopolitical landscape.

5. Research and Analysis

Amidst the Russian state discourse from 2012 to 2023, this research unravels a narrative tapestry that intricately weaves together power, identity, and ontological security dynamics. Five salient themes emerge, collectively shedding light on Russia's motivations in the Russo-Ukrainian War. At its core lies the recurrent motif of Russia's unique and distinct national identity, a multifaceted construct that is framed in juxtaposition with the Western Other. This investigation begins with Theme One, revealing the Kremlin's emphasis on Russia's unique historical identity as a foundation of its ontological security and policymaking. Continuing to Theme Two, the depiction of shared ties between Russian and Ukrainian communities are explored. This discourse employs historical, linguistic, and cultural affinities to position Ukraine as an extension of Russia's influence, replete with a deep-rooted identification. The discourse in Theme Three centres around Russia's historical claims to Crimean and Ukrainian territory. This narrative bolsters Russia's rationale for annexation, portraying it as a rightful restoration of justice and countermeasure against perceived Western influence. Within Theme Four, the narrative of an alleged neo-Nazi Ukrainian regime solidifies domestic support for Russian interventions. This casts Ukraine as a battleground for defending traditional values and Russian identity. Theme Five unfurls the perception of the West as a hostile force, aiming to undermine Russia's sovereignty and cultural integrity. This narrative positions Ukraine's Westernisation as a major ontological and strategic threat.

Theme	Title
One	Redefining Russian Identity
Two	Ukraine as an Extension of Russian Identity
Three	Russian Ownership of Crimea and Ukrainian Territory.
Four	An Illegal, Despotic and Neo-Nazi Ukrainian Government.
Five	A Hostile and Anti-Russian West That Seeks to Divide and Weaken Russia.

Table 2. Relevant Themes Identified in Russian State Discourse.

5.1 Theme One: Redefining Russia's Identity

Between 2012 and 2023, the discourse consistently emphasises Russia's unique identity as a sovereign, independent, multi-ethnic great-power or centre of civilisation. On his return to the Kremlin in 2012, Putin portrayed Russia's identity as the guiding principle and cornerstone of his policies. This discourse persisted over time (2014a, 2014b, 2014c, 2022a, 2022b), signifying the transformation of Russian identity into a tangible security and foreign policy concern (Zevelev 2016, 9). This renewed focus on identity is, as Putin believes (2013), "the consequences of the national catastrophes of the twentieth century", including the dissolution of the Soviet Union, which created a profound identity crisis for Russia. In search of a new identity and growth model, Russia initially turned its attention towards the West, aspiring to join the ranks of dominant democratic and capitalist nations (Tsygankov 2016, 126). In this narrative, the Kremlin associated itself with the victorious Western principles of the Cold War era, while implicitly distancing itself from Russia's Soviet past by portraying others as less developed and democratic. Putin's 2012 return to the Kremlin heralded a pivot in Russian identity narratives (Zevelev 2016, 8). This reimagined Self emphasised Russia's autonomy from the Western Other, rejecting efforts to align with Western liberalism.

In his inaugural address, Putin (2012) emphasised Russia's independence as a distinct civilisation, stating that Russia's "future is dependent on Russia's ability to become the leader and centre of gravity for the whole of Eurasia". He claimed that "Russia had restored its dignity as a nation", implying that they had finally shed their seemingly chaotic and indecent post-Soviet Self. In a parallel narrative to Putin, Lavrov (2012) asserted that the scope of global development is not confined solely to the liberal-democratic model, advocating for an international "system based on a partnership of civilisations", with Russia being one of these. Within this framework, Lavrov emphasised the notion of "Eurasian integration", where Russia, propelled by "Russian language and culture", assumes a central position in fostering collaboration and unity across the Eurasian region, synonymous with the former USSR. This strategy echoes certain aspects of the historical ties and interdependencies that existed within the Soviet bloc, where economic and political unity existed within the USSR's centralised authority. The renewed invocation of Eurasianism in the state discourse could be seen as a revival of this historical legacy, albeit under new geopolitical dynamics. Thus, from 2012 onwards, the discourse began highlighting Russia's identity as a centre of civilisation, setting it apart from the Western Other.

In his 2013 Valdai International Discussion Club speech, Putin began openly criticising attempts to impose a Western liberal-capitalist development model on Russia. Instead, he advocated for state decisions to be rooted in national identity (2013): “Such primitive borrowing and attempts to civilise Russia from abroad were not accepted by an absolute majority of our people. This is because the desire for independence and sovereignty in spiritual, ideological, and foreign policy spheres is an integral part of our national character.” The word choice here conveys a negative view on foreign influence and intervention in Russia’s affairs. It suggests that Western approaches are unsophisticated, oppressive, and disrespectful to Russia’s distinct identity and historical trajectory. By framing foreign interactions through this lens, the Kremlin effectively pushes the notion that it is Russia’s duty to resist such influences to preserve its autonomy and unique character.

The persistent portrayal of the West as a force seeking to impose a standardised and exploitative model of statehood, erasing individual national identities, remains a consistent thread in this narrative. This continuity will be further explored in Theme Five. Within this context, the Western Other acts as a backdrop against which Russia’s self-identity is defined. Putin condemns the West’s “standardised model of a unipolar world” (2013), implying the oppressive imposition of rigid and uniform values by the dominance of one power or group of nations (See also, Putin 2014c, 2022b, 2022e, 2022f). In contrast, Russia is portrayed as a “guardian of the God-given diversity of the world,” (2013) evoking a sense of natural order and divine purpose. This affirmation of identity offers a platform to justify Russia’s assumed civilisational status. Such is evident in Russia’s historical pursuit to “bring balance to the international stage” (2013), echoing Cold War-era balance of power dynamics and stressing the divergence from Western dominance. Lavrov (2018) later remarks that “Russian people always had their own cultural matrix and spirituality and never blended entirely with the West”, alluding to the futile attempt to impose a Western development model on Russia. The use of “entirely” acknowledges that while some integration occurred, the distinct nature of the Russian identity ultimately prevailed. In sum, the depiction of Russia as a guardian of diversity and harmony, in contrast to Western imposition of uniformity, forms a consistent narrative thread that underscores the uniqueness of Russia’s national identity and its role on the global stage. This narrative serves to reinforce the notion that Russia is different from other states, necessitating that it be understood and approached on its own terms rather than through the prism of Western

norms and expectations. It positions Russia as a distinct player in international affairs, driven by its own historical, cultural, and spiritual dimensions.

Putin's 2013 Valdai speech illuminated the pressing need to reconfigure Russia's national identity. He emphasised that "finding and strengthening national identity really is fundamental for Russia," hinging on their "history, values, and traditions," as well as their "shared goals and responsibilities." This emphasis on key identity elements, deliberately left open to interpretation, creates a space for strategic framing. The Kremlin's narrative, rooted in historical foundations, is evident in Putin's assertion that Russia's history is the cornerstone of its culture, identity, and broad "worldview." This historical bedrock provides stability, continuity, and shapes Russia's "mission as a civilisation." Putin's language exudes confidence and determination, presenting Russia's historical legacy as impervious. The nation is depicted as resolute in navigating its unique historical trajectory. Any deviation from established traditions is seen as a potential existential threat, stemming from the tumultuous events of the twentieth century.

This shift towards civilisational thinking had a direct impact on policymaking. With the goal of positioning Russia as a central hub in the Eurasian landscape, Putin pursued the integration of states within the former Soviet space. This initiative evolved into the establishment of the Eurasian Economic Union (EEU).³ Putin framed this undertaking as "a project for maintaining the identity of nations in the historical Eurasian space" and empower the post-Soviet region to evolve into an autonomous nucleus, "rather than remaining on the outskirts of Europe and Asia" (2013). This not only reflects his stance on strengthening Eurasian autonomy but also underlines his resistance against the imposition of an all-encompassing, homogenous Western identity. The concept of shaping a parallel "Eurasian realm" alongside Europe and Asia carries significant implications, symbolising an endeavour to secure Russia's ontological security within its nascent civilisational identity. In this vein, Putin's statements against Western integration and development procedures, particularly during the 2014 EU-Russia Summit, take on deeper meaning. He rebuked the European Union's Eastern Partnership Plan (EaP) for generating "new dividing lines," emphasising the necessity of mutual cooperation between the EU and the EEU (2014d). This sentiment echoes his aspiration to position Russia on an equal

³ The EEU consists of five member states: Russia, Belarus, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan and Armenia. It is an ambitious project that aims to achieve Eurasian economic integration via the creation of a customs union and single economic space, much like the EU (Van der Togt et al. 2015).

footing with the EU, aiming for recognition as a distinct civilisation. Therefore, the strategic pursuit of an autonomous Eurasian space, safeguarding identity and resisting Western homogeneity, reflects Russia's ontological security concerns and exemplifies how its civilisational narrative shapes RFP.

This theme has delved into the discourses surrounding Russian identity. Initiated with President Putin's return to the Kremlin in 2012, a pronounced shift steered the state narrative towards Russia's historical roots and civilisational essence. This realignment emphasised autonomy from Western paradigms and asserted Russia's unique cultural identity, anchored in enigmatic concepts like "cultural and spiritual codes", "cultural matrix", "genes", and the "Russian ethnos", which underscore Russian distinctiveness, albeit with ambiguous meanings (Zevelev 2016, 9). The Kremlin's articulation of a national identity anchored in history, values, and traditions formed the bedrock of its self-perception. This transformation coincided with developments in the Eurasian integration project, signifying Russia's ambition to regain centrality in the wider Eurasian context. Through this reframing, the Kremlin aimed to reaffirm its role as a distinct and influential civilisation. This sets the stage for understanding the intricate interplay between Russia, Ukraine, and the dynamics that shape RFP. The subsequent theme delves into the discourse on the intertwined identity of Russia and Ukraine, offering insights into the Kremlin's perspective on their relationship and its impact on RFP.

5.2 Theme Two: Ukraine as an Extension of Russian Identity

Russian state discourse consistently emphasises a shared identity between Russians and Ukrainians, encompassing historical, cultural, linguistic, and spiritual bonds. This strategic emphasis seeks to shape public opinion, nurturing a sense of historical and cultural kinship between the two nations. By framing Ukraine as integral to Russia's larger world, Putin endeavours to validate Russia's involvement in Ukrainian affairs and establish influence over Ukraine's trajectory. This forms the ideological foundation for Russia's interventions in Ukraine's domestic sphere, most notably during the 2014 and 2022 invasions (Putin 2014a, 2014b, 2015).

The assertion of a shared identity between Ukraine and Russia is characteristic of the Kremlin's concerted efforts to sway Ukraine towards integration with the EEU. While the EU's EaP framework proposed the Association Agreement and Comprehensive Free Trade Area to

Ukraine, the Kremlin fervently advocated for Kyiv's participation within the EEU.⁴ This push gained momentum in late 2013 when Ukrainian President Yanukovich publicly declared his country's intention to join the EEU. In swift response, Ukrainians advocating closer ties with the EU took to the streets, fervently demanding Yanukovich's resignation. The aftermath of Yanukovich's resignation witnessed a significant turning point in Ukraine's relationship with Russia. The south-eastern regions of Ukraine, where a substantial population of Russian speakers reside, became focal points of contention. These regions, including Crimea and parts of Donetsk and Luhansk, saw heightened tensions and protests, with some advocating for closer ties with Russia (Sakwa 2016, 100-148). The Kremlin seized upon these sentiments to justify its military support for separatist forces in these regions, framing it as a response to the protection of ethnic Russians facing alleged discrimination and danger due to the rise of a purportedly Nazi and extremist Ukrainian government. This complex situation forms a core aspect of Theme Four.

Amidst these unfolding events, Russian forces entered Crimea, setting the stage for a subsequent referendum where Crimeans reportedly voted to align with the Russian Federation. In defence of this move, Putin (2014c) asserted the democratic and legal validity of the referendum, citing the "right to self-determination." However, the United Nations dismissed the legitimacy of the referendum, designating it as invalid (UNGA, 2014). The dynamics of the Kremlin's justification for the Crimean invasion will be explored further in the subsequent theme.

Putin (2015) justified Russia's actions by claiming that some Ukrainians "consider themselves Russian regardless of what their passports say". This emphasis on self-identification suggests that Putin views citizenship as more than just a legal status; it becomes a marker of cultural, ethnic, or linguistic affiliation. Furthermore, by asserting that certain Ukrainian citizens consider themselves Russian regardless of their legal nationality, Putin challenges the authority of the Ukrainian government over its citizens. It implies that Russia sees itself as a protector and representative for these individuals, undermining Ukraine's sovereignty and authority.

⁴ For comprehensive analyses of the different faces of power relations in EU-Russia relations in this period, see Wilson 2014 and Casier 2018.

The persistent deployment of fraternal and familial language strategically portrays the Ukrainian people as inextricably tied to Russians (2014c, 2015a, 2015b, 2017, 2022c, 2022e). His referral to Ukrainians as “our comrades” and “people bound by blood, by family ties” (2022a) espouses a sense of kinship and unity to his Russian audience. It underscores the idea of a deep-rooted genealogical connection that has become an integral aspect of Ukrainian identity. It is noteworthy that the use of “comrades”, a term associated with the Soviet era, taps into a sense of Russian nostalgia for that period, reinforcing the historical ties between the two nations.

Putin’s portrayal of Ukraine “as part of our greater Russian, or Russian-Ukrainian, world” (2015) establishes an inherent hierarchy, positioning Russia at the core of this shared identity, whilst picturing Ukraine as a subordinate or dependent entity. The use of the term “greater Russian world” suggests a sphere of influence where Russia plays the dominant role, reinforcing the notion of Russia’s natural entitlement to guide and shape Ukraine’s trajectory. Moreover, by presenting Ukrainians as merely an extension of Russians within this “greater Russian world”, the discourse denies the distinctiveness of Ukrainians as a nationality. Taking this argument to its logical conclusion, such a perspective can be seen as challenging the very existence of Ukrainians as a separate and distinct people.

This sentiment is also evident in Putin’s 2017 Valdai Speech, where he professes that he “really regard[s] the Ukrainian people as a brotherly nation if not just one nation, part of the Russian nation”, a statement that carries undertones of Russian national proprietorship over the Ukrainian people. This approach raises important questions about the autonomy and agency of Ukrainians in defining their own identity and future. It raises concerns about cultural and political assimilation, where Ukrainians might be coerced into conforming to a Russian-centric identity. Importantly, by pushing the sentiment that Ukrainians are essentially Russian, Putin effectively silences their voice, asserting that he can speak on their behalf.

The depiction of Ukraine as an extension of Russia’s identity serves as a cornerstone in the Kremlin’s rationale for intervening in Ukrainian affairs. However, this narrative’s implications extend beyond mere geopolitical manoeuvring. It touches upon deeper issues of cultural sovereignty, national self-determination, and the right of a people to define their own identity. This narrative furnishes a pretext for engaging in Ukrainian politics, ostensibly to protect “our people” and uphold Russian cultural, historical, and lingual ties. This strategic positioning

further cements Russia's role as a custodian of shared heritage, fortifying its emergent civilisational identity. As the narrative unfolds, the subsequent theme delves into how the Kremlin transcends this shared identity narrative to assert territorial claims over Ukrainian and Crimean land.

5.3 Theme Three: Russian Ownership of Crimea and Ukrainian Territory.

The discourse concerning Russian ownership of Crimea and Ukrainian territory illuminates a multifaceted narrative crafted by the Kremlin to rationalise its actions and assert historical and cultural claims over the region. Putin adroitly employs historical, cultural, and emotional references to bolster Russia's entitlement whilst downplaying Ukraine's national identity and Crimea's Ukrainian identity.

Shortly after the 2014 annexation of Crimea, Putin proclaimed that Crimea has "always been an inseparable part of Russia" in the "hearts and minds of the people" (2014a). This emotional-intellectual amalgamation serves to bypass the constraints of formal legality and evoke a sense of historical inevitability. By focusing on the "hearts and minds of the people", Putin's narrative emphasises a shared historical identity that predates contemporary legal frameworks. This approach contrasts with the more legalistic discourse surrounding the right to self-determination, transcending legal interpretations to assert a timeless, almost preordained bond. The effect is to paint the annexation of Crimea as an organic reintegration rather than a geopolitical and legalistic manoeuvre, tapping into a deep-seated narrative of historical unity. This resonates with Russia's broader identity-building efforts, aligning its actions with a narrative of historical continuity and cultural cohesion.

The Kremlin enforces its specific interpretation of history as the definitive truth, leaving little room for diverse perspectives. For instance, Putin underscores the historical and religious significance of Crimea to Russia, portraying it as a spiritual cornerstone for his nation's development. He labels Crimea as "the spiritual source of the development of a multifaceted but solid Russian nation and a centralised Russian state" (2014a). By highlighting the ancient city of Chersonesus (Korsun), Putin establishes a connection between Crimea and Grand Prince Vladimir's baptism, a pivotal event that facilitated the spread of Christianity throughout the "Rus". However, the usage of the term "Rus" is contentious, as it references the medieval East Slavic state known as Kyivan Rus, encompassing present-day areas of Ukraine as well as

Russia. Within this context, Putin strategically underscores an exclusivist interpretation that establishes an unbroken continuum between Crimea, Russia, and the expansive historical legacy of Kyivan Rus. As a result, Putin's rhetoric constructs a historical lineage that exalts Russia's historical continuity and territorial entitlement, while simultaneously marginalising competing Ukrainian narratives.

Concurrently, Putin employs evocative language to liken Crimea's importance to Russians to that of the "Temple Mount in Jerusalem for followers of Islam and Judaism" (2014a), further emphasising its cultural and spiritual significance. By drawing this parallel, he establishes Crimea as a cherished and sacred territory for Russia, deeply ingrained in the collective consciousness of the Russian people. Putin's assertion that Crimea will always be considered as such highlights the durability of Russia's historical and spiritual bond to the peninsula.

Amidst the discussion surrounding the disavowal of Crimea's Ukrainian identity, a distinct narrative emerges regarding Russia's assertions of sovereignty over Crimea. Putin condemns the Soviet-era transfer of Crimea to Ukraine, deeming it a violation of constitutional and ethnic norms (2014a, 2022). This denunciation seeks to establish the idea that Crimea's inclusion within Ukraine was a departure from historical and legal legitimacy, presenting it as an arbitrary deviation rather than a lawful and natural course of events.

Moreover, Putin's characterisation of Ukraine as "Vladimir Lenin's Ukraine" (2022a) functions as a strategic move that repudiates the very foundation of the USSR, casting doubt on the historical continuity and authenticity of Ukrainian national identity. This not only lays the foundation for Russia's territorial incursion but also establishes the idea that modern Ukrainian statehood is a recently engineered construct, thereby reinforcing Russia's overarching control narrative. This intricate interplay between historical disqualification and territorial assertion demonstrates the Kremlin's strategy to reshape historical memory and consolidate its narrative of legitimacy and control.

Through stressing that this narrative is universally accepted as "common knowledge" (2022a), Putin strengthens the idea of a single historical truth. He states that, "it seems to us that, generally speaking, we know all these facts" (2022a). By asserting that the shared awareness of these facts is prevalent, Putin enforces them as the absolute truth, leaving no space for alternate viewpoints. This authoritative stance serves to reinforce the Kremlin's interpretation,

potentially pressuring individuals unfamiliar with this history to conform due to potential embarrassment or a sense of social pressure within the audience.

The discourse also reinforces Russia's historical ties to Ukraine and the Black Sea littoral by referencing military campaigns and territorial expansions of the Russian Empire. Putin highlights the conquests and incorporations of territories like Ochakov and Novorossiia, using them as evidence of Russia's historical claims to these regions (2014a). Putin suggests that these areas were rightfully Russian due to their historical association with the Russian Empire and its military figures. Notably, Putin (2014b) employs the term Novorossiia [New Russia] to delineate south-eastern Ukrainian regions with substantial Russian-speaking populations, harkening back to Empress Catherine the Great's territorial acquisitions. This term encapsulates a distinct historical era marked by the formidable expansion of the Russian empire. Collectively, these historical references and territorial allusions construct an image of Russia's longstanding historical claims to the region, further shaping the narrative of Russia's dominant relationship with Ukraine.

This narrative builds a sense that the return of Crimea and South-eastern Ukrainian land to Russia is the correction of a historical injustice. For instance, in his references to Peter the Great and the Great Northern War, Putin presents a narrative of "returning lands" rather than "taking them away" (2022d). He closes his speech with an inference that the 2014 and 2022 invasions of Ukraine were enacted on a similar principles: "clearly, it fell to our lot to return and reinforce as well. And if we operate on the premise that these basic values constitute the basis of our existence, we will certainly succeed in achieving our goals." This framing of territorial expansion as a return to rightful lands not only justifies Russia's actions but positions them as a historical restoration rather than aggressive annexation. This seamless interweaving of historical narratives and cultural continuity shapes a compelling image that undoubtedly resonates deeply with Russian citizens, solidifying their support for Russia's actions in the region.

In this theme, Putin weaves historical events and figures to substantiate Russia's claims to Crimean and Ukrainian territory. By portraying territorial expansion as a restitution of historical heritage, Putin justifies the actions as the rightful preservation of Russia's historical and cultural identity. This narrative bolsters Russia's ontological security, providing a stable and coherent identity, particularly in the face of a Ukraine pivoting Westward, which is

perceived as a potential threat to this historical identity. Theme Four delves into the portrayal of the Ukrainian government as despotic and neo-Nazi, further underlining Russia's perceived need for intervention.

5.4 Theme Four: The Depiction of an Illegal, Despotic and Neo-Nazi Ukrainian Government.

Through careful use of language, imagery, and word choice, Putin portrays Russia as a guardian of Ukrainian and Russian-speaking populations, victims of an illegitimate and radical regime in Ukraine that seeks to deprive any shared identity with Russia. The depiction has persisted and strengthened since the 2014 Crimean invasion and has descended into ferocious propaganda for the war support (Putin 2014a, 2014b, 2014c, 2015, 2017, 2022a, 2022b, 2022c, 2022e, 2022f).

Forwarding a narrative of deception and deprivation, Putin laments that despite expecting "Ukraine to remain our good neighbour [...] time and time again attempts were made to deprive Russians [living in Ukraine] of their historical memory, even of their language, and to subject them to forced assimilation" (2014a). The imagery of cultural erasure and assimilation paints Ukrainian state actions as oppressive and unjust, projecting a sentiment of victimhood among Russian speakers. By doing so, Putin creates an image of a hostile and oppressive environment for Russian identity in Ukraine, with the Ukrainian regime "rooting out the Russian language and culture and promoting assimilation" (2022a). Given the narrative of rediscovering and protecting national identity through the nurturement of shared histories, culture, language, and spirituality (Theme One), the image of a tyrannical group "rooting out" these time-honoured and treasured values becomes particularly distressing.

As mentioned in Theme Two, the state discourse further characterised the protests and eventual change in leadership in Ukraine as an "armed coup" orchestrated by "nationalists, neo-Nazis, Russophobes, and anti-Semites" (2014a). In the same 2014 speech, Putin argued that "those who stood behind the latest events in Ukraine...wanted to seize power and would stop short of nothing. They resorted to terror, murder, and riots" (2014a). By using these terms, Putin employs strong and emotionally charged language to evoke images of radicalism and violence. Furthermore, the consistent charge of terrorism is an implicit denial of Ukrainian statehood given that terrorism conventionally refers to non-state violence. This portrayal seeks to

undermine the legitimacy of the Ukrainian government and justify Russia's intervention as a necessary measure to protect victimised populations.

Through the portrayal of the Ukrainian regime as Nazi and reference of historical figures like Bandera and Hitler (Putin 2014a, 2014c, 2022b, 2022f), the discourse links the Ukrainian regime with extremist ideologies, emphasising a narrative of historical aggression. The consistent linkage of the Ukrainian regime with Nazism not only serves as a rhetorical tool to discredit the Ukrainian regime, but also enables the Kremlin to evoke a sense of moral outrage and indignation among the Russian population. Russia's experience in World War Two, commonly known as the Great Patriotic War in Russia, is reminisced as an episode of abundant patriotism, unity, and eventual glory in the memory of the Russian population. The allegation of Ukrainian Nazism undoubtedly stirs deep emotions in the Russian populace, amassing sympathy and legitimacy for intervention, whilst simultaneously solidifying Russia's identity as an agent of justice against the face of evil forces.

However, the narrative of rampant extremist violence in Ukraine also contributes to the dehumanisation of Ukrainian identity. For instance, during the 2022 Valdai International Discussion Club, Putin claimed that Ukrainians cooperated "with Hitler during WWII, when Ukrainian collaborators were used in campaigns to exterminate Russians, Poles, Jews, and Belarusians. It is a well-known historical fact: killing squads assigned Bandera followers with the dirtiest and bloodiest jobs" (2022f). This framing implies that Ukrainians were not only complicit but active participants in the genocidal horrors of the Holocaust, implicating them in the sufferings of other nationalities and ethnic groups during that time. By asserting that the "dirtiest and bloodiest jobs" were assigned to Ukrainians, Putin insinuates a disturbing narrative that Ukrainians possess an inherent propensity for cruelty, lacking empathy and kindness, and are willing to perpetrate unspeakable atrocities upon command. This portrayal seeks to strip Ukrainians of their humanity, casting them as ruthless agents of violence and chaos, while simultaneously casting Russia as the virtuous defender of civilisation. In this regard, the discourse reinforces the idea that Ukraine's historical actions are part of an inherent pattern, implying that these alleged actions are reflective of the broader Ukrainian identity. This poses an interesting contrast to Putin's earlier use of familial language towards Ukrainians, signifying how this narrative has degraded into abrasive war propaganda.

This sentiment is furthered in the Kremlin's construction of a condemning image of the Ukrainian state as a relentless source of violence and terror. Through potent language and evocative imagery, Putin stresses the horror and brutality of the Kyiv regime. He frequently directs attention to the unrelenting fighting in the Donbass region, underscoring the constant onslaught of attacks on civilian communities. By declaring that "not a single day goes by without Donbass communities coming under shelling attacks", Putin reinforces the portrayal of Ukraine as a state that perpetuates violence against its own citizens (2022a). The imagery of ceaseless bombardment creates an impression of enduring fear and insecurity, painting a grim picture of life for innocent civilians trapped in an unending cycle of conflict. Moreover, Putin's mention of the "killing of civilians, the blockade, the abuse of people, including children, women, and the elderly, continues unabated" (2022a) deliberately evokes strong emotions of empathy and outrage. The inclusion of specific vulnerable groups, such as children, women, and the elderly, is a calculated effort to highlight the sufferings of the most defenceless members of society. This portrayal exploits the universal tendency to empathise with the suffering of innocent civilians, thus enhancing Russia's narrative of Ukraine as an aggressor, willing to inflict untold suffering on its own people.

In 2022, Putin asserts that "a wave of violence swept Ukrainian cities, including a series of high-profile and unpunished murders" (Putin, 2022a). This statement emphasises the widespread nature of the violence and chaos, painting a picture of pandemonium in Ukraine. The quote continues: "One shudders at the memories of the terrible tragedy in Odessa, where peaceful protesters were brutally murdered, burned alive in the House of Trade Unions" (Putin, 2022a). This vivid description creates a visceral impact on the reader or listener, evoking a profound sense of horror and outrage. Moreover, Putin claims that "the criminals who committed that atrocity have never been punished, and no one is even looking for them. But we know their names and we will do everything to punish them, find them and bring them to justice" (Putin, 2022a). This claim suggests that the Ukrainian regime is both responsible for these terrible acts and apathetic to the suffering. By stating that Russia intends to seek justice, Putin enforces Russia's identity as the lead actor committed to addressing the injustices inflicted upon innocent people.

In conclusion, Theme Four highlights how the Russian state constructs a narrative that demonises the Ukrainian government, depicting it as illegal, despotic, and extremist. This portrayal serves to justify Russia's intervention as a defender of innocent people and their

rights, painting a picture of a hostile environment for Russian identity in Ukraine. By framing its actions as defensive and pre-emptive, Russia seeks to validate its involvement in the conflict as a necessary means to secure its identity and protect its population. This theme lays the groundwork for the subsequent theme, which explores the Kremlin's depiction of the West as hostile and anti-Russian, seeking to divide and weaken Russia by supporting the Ukrainian regime.

5.5 Theme Five: A Hostile and Anti-Russian West That Seeks to Divide and Weaken Russia.

The discourse surrounding the theme of Western hostility is abundant in the state discourse, offering a glimpse into how the Russian state frames its perception of Western actions and intentions. The language and imagery used in the discourse emphasise a narrative of Western aggression, betrayal, and attempts to undermine Russia's sovereignty and interests. The vehemence with how the Kremlin portrays the West increases throughout 2012 to 2023 in tandem with the West's support for Ukrainian defence against Russia.

The image of a clash of Western and Russian identity is manifested in Putin's charges of Western moral degradation. This narrative is consistent throughout the discourse, with Putin declaring in his 2013 Valdai Speech:

“We can see how many of the Euro-Atlantic countries are actually rejecting their roots, including the Christian values that constitute the basis of Western civilisation. They are denying moral principles and all traditional identities: national, cultural, religious and even sexual. They are implementing policies that equate large families with same-sex partnerships, belief in God with the belief in Satan” (2013).

This framing positions Russia as a defender of traditional values against what is presented as a decline in moral standards in the West. By contrasting Russia's adherence to what Putin refers to as “Christian values” and “traditional identities” with the West's alleged rejection of these values, Putin creates a sense of moral superiority and cultural authenticity among the Russian population. This taps into the concept of ontological security by reinforcing a stable and coherent biographical narrative in the face of perceived threats. It also builds a sense of disgust

and revulsion towards Western society, which intensifies throughout the period. For instance, in 2023 Putin seeks to evoke strong emotional responses in his condemnation of the West's "destruction of the family, of cultural and national identity, [their] perversion and abuse of children, including paedophilia, all of which are declared normal in their life" (2023). This narrative not only projects Russia as the guardian of moral integrity and Christian values, but it also plays a role in shaping Russia's stance in international affairs. By framing the West as morally corrupt and ideologically incompatible, Russia can more convincingly present itself as a distinct, alternative, and morally sound centre of civilisation, furthering its foreign policy objectives and asserting its influence on the international stage.

Putin consistently draws parallels between the situation in Ukraine and the broader global context. In 2014, he stated that the Ukrainian situation is "like a mirror" reflecting worldwide developments over the past decades, emphasising the instability that followed the dissolution of the bipolar world order (2014a). The discourse frequently positions key Western international institutions as "degrading", "eroding", or "breaking down" rather than advancing (2014a, 2017, 2022f). He contends that Western nations, with the United States at the forefront, prioritise the use of force over adherence to international law in their policies, embodying a belief in their "exceptionalism" and the idea that they alone can dictate global destinies (2013, 2014a, 2022b). Employing phrases like "rule of the gun" and "exclusivity and exceptionalism", Putin underscores the perception of the West as acting arbitrarily and unilaterally (2014a). This not only decries the perceived tyranny of the West, but also reinforces Russia's stance as a counterbalance to what Putin sees as Western exceptionalism. By depicting Western international institutions as degrading and prioritising force over international law, he underscores Russia's role in upholding an alternative narrative of order and stability, bolstering its international standing and ontological security.

The discourse extends to Western interference in the internal affairs of other nations, including Yugoslavia, Afghanistan, Iraq, and Libya (Putin 2013, 2014a, 2014b, 2015a, 2015b, 2017, 2022b, 2022f, 2023). Here, Putin frames the Western interventions as illegal, aggressive and ignorant, creating "bloody, non-healing wounds and the curse of international terrorism and extremism" (2022b). Additionally, by mentioning "controlled 'colour' revolutions" and "standards imposed on these nations that did not correspond to their way of life," (2014a) Putin paints a picture of Western interventions deliberately leading to destabilisation and chaos in the post-Soviet space.

This portrayal aligns with the broader subject of Russia's ontological security and civilisational identity. It positions the West as an antagonist to Russia's values and interests, reinforcing the idea that the imposition of Western models of governance leads to disorder and violence. This sentiment is particularly significant in the context of Russia's experience after the fall of the Soviet Union, where Western influence is framed as contributing to internal turmoil and upheaval (as explored in Theme One). This narrative not only strengthens the Kremlin's position as a distinct pole, autonomous to the West, but also aims to undermine the credibility of Western institutions and their approach to global affairs.

Moreover, a recurring theme of "containment" emerges in the discourse, with Putin stating that the West seeks to weaken and divide Russia: "we have every reason to assume that the infamous policy of containment, led in the 18th, 19th and 20th centuries, continues today" (2014a). The imagery of "sweeping us into a corner" and "crossing the line" underscores Russia's perception of being cornered and pushed into a confrontational stance (2014a). The language used suggests a defensive posture, with phrases like "if you compress the spring all the way to its limit, it will snap back hard" projecting a willingness to respond to perceived threats to their identity (2014a).

Putin's condemnation of NATO expansionism reveals a multifaceted approach to framing the threats posed by the alliance. On one hand, Putin emphasises the physical threat posed by NATO's enlargement towards Russia's borders. He likens NATO's expansion to the movement of "military infrastructure at our borders" (2014a), conjuring images of military encroachment. His comment that "NATO remains a military alliance, and we are against having a military alliance making itself at home right in our backyard or in our historic territory" (2014a) exemplifies this concern. However, the discourse also includes a nuanced portrayal of NATO expansionism as a threat to Russia's identity. He contends that NATO's enlargement embodies a larger challenge to Russia's sovereignty and national identity, asserting that "they are constantly trying to sweep us into a corner because we have an independent position, because we maintain it and because we call things like they are and do not engage in hypocrisy" (2014a). Here, Putin introduces the idea that NATO's actions aim to undermine Russia's autonomous stance and to impose a homogenising Western narrative upon it. This reflects a less material perspective that emphasises ideational factors, such as identity and normative clashes, as the causes of war. In comparing these portrayals, it becomes evident that Putin employs a dual

strategy: he highlights both the physical and ideational dimensions of NATO's expansionism to craft a narrative that resonates with both geopolitical concerns and identity-based anxieties. This strategy enables him to tap into a broad range of public sentiments, from fears of military encroachment to concerns about cultural and ideological subjugation. By invoking both dimensions, Putin aims to bolster Russia's resistance to NATO expansion while solidifying his position as a defender of Russia's territorial and identity-based interests on the global stage.

Amidst the 2022 invasion of Ukraine, in response to Western sanctions and support for Ukraine, anti-Western sentiments gained even more prominence. The Kremlin heightened its emphasis on the purported backing of separatism in Russia by Western powers, asserting their intention to erode and fragment the country. This portrayal paints the West as harbouring ulterior motives to capitalise on Russia's domestic challenges and sow internal discord:

“The goal of that part of the West is to weaken, divide and ultimately destroy our country. They are saying openly now that in 1991 they managed to split up the Soviet Union and now is the time to do the same to Russia, which must be divided into numerous regions that would be at deadly feud with each other. They devised these plans long ago.” (Putin 2022c).

This implies a long-standing antagonism from the West towards Russia. Terms like “total de-sovereignisation,” “colonisers,” and “Russophobia” (2022e) portray the West as imperialistic and racist, with an agenda to subjugate Russia. The discourse suggests that the West views Russia as a threat to its global dominance, leading to actions aimed at containing and controlling Russia. Putin maintains that the West “have always dreamed about” a plan to “weaken and break up Russia [...] to divide our state and set our peoples against each other, and to condemn them to poverty and extinction. They cannot rest easy knowing that there is such a great country with this huge territory in the world” (2022e). Here Russia is depicted as a nation under continual siege from wicked external forces due to its natural characteristics, implying a long-term, congenital conspiracy against Russia. It taps into the historical narrative of Russia as a formidable power that has faced external threats and interventions throughout its history. This narrative ties into the collective memory of Russia's past struggles against external forces and invasions, fostering a sense of vigilance and defensiveness to protect its sovereignty and identity. In this context, Putin's statements serve as a rallying cry, reinforcing the sense of unity and identity among Russians. It bolsters the belief that Russia's existence is

under threat, contributing to the Kremlin's efforts to consolidate domestic support and justify its actions by portraying them as necessary to safeguard Russia's national identity, ontological security, and survival.

In conclusion, the discourse surrounding Theme Five emphasises a narrative of a hostile, neo-colonial and morally corrupt West seeking to undermine Russia's sovereignty, interfere in its internal affairs, and strengthen its dominance on the global stage. These charges of Western moral and institutional degradation serve to consolidate support by framing Russia as a bastion of traditional values and moral rectitude. It aligns with the concept of ontological security by reinforcing a stable sense of identity, and it contributes to the larger narrative of Russia's historical endurance and spiritual strength. In this way, the Westernisation of Ukraine is positioned as a deliberate strategy to erode Russia's sphere of influence and challenge its historical and civilisational identity.

5.6 Summary

The thematic discourse analysis undertaken in this research unveils a nuanced tapestry of narratives, images, and power dynamics that collectively shape Russia's ontological security concerns. These themes provide insights into how the Kremlin meticulously constructs and reinforces a narrative that both fortifies Russia's national identity and advances its geopolitical ambitions. Across five themes, a consistent thread emerges: the image of a westernised Ukraine presenting a tangible threat to Russia's sense of identity and security.

Beginning with Theme One, the Kremlin accentuates the uniqueness of Russia's identity as a foundational pillar of ontological security. The imagery of Russia as a distinct and resilient civilisation, poised against the perceived encroachment of Western values, echoes through Putin's speeches. This narrative, entwined with the idea of Russia's historical mission as a civilisation, works to reaffirm the collective identity and historical continuity of the Russian people. By juxtaposing Russia's purported historical authenticity with the perceived facelessness of Western liberalism, this narrative constructs a protective boundary around Russia's identity.

Theme Two delves into the shared identity between Russian and Ukrainian populations. Here, the discourse exploits historical, linguistic, and cultural affinities to position Ukraine as an

organic extension of Russia's sphere of influence. A distinction is leveraged between contemporary Ukrainian citizenship and the perceived genuine identification of the Ukrainian people with Russia, grounded in ideational, historical, and emotional realms. By depicting Ukraine's orientation towards the West as a betrayal of this identity, Russia projects itself as the protector of its linguistic and cultural kin, forging a bond rooted in historical continuity.

The discourse in Theme Three revolves around Russia's purported ownership of Crimean and Ukrainian territory. This narrative amplifies Russia's historical claims to these regions, bolstering its argument for annexation and invasion. Implicitly, the annexation of Crimea serves as a countermeasure against the perceived Western influence in Ukraine, reinforcing the idea that protecting Russian-speaking populations necessitates territorial expansion.

Moving to Theme Four, the portrayal of an alleged illegal, despotic, and neo-Nazi Ukrainian government weaves a powerful narrative that solidifies domestic support for Russia's military interventions. This narrative casts the Ukrainian regime as a puppet of Western interests, seeking to eradicate traditional values that Russia ostensibly upholds. By framing Ukraine as a battleground for the defence of moral and cultural authenticity, the Kremlin fosters a sense of unity and identity among the Russian population.

Within Theme Five, the image of a hostile and anti-Russian West comes to the fore. This narrative depicts Western powers as seeking to undermine Russia's sovereignty and weaken its integrity. The Westernisation of Ukraine is positioned as a deliberate strategy to erode Russia's sphere of influence and challenge its historical and civilisational identity. Within this theme, protests against NATO expansion and alleged Western interference in Ukraine are depicted as detrimental to both Ukraine's populace and institutions, as well as Russia's security. The prior two themes are particularly pertinent to the 2022 invasion, growing in significance alongside the military campaign.

Collectively, these themes form a comprehensive narrative architecture that revolves around the perceived threat posed by a westernised Ukraine. By depicting Ukraine's alignment with the West as a betrayal of shared identity, historical ties, and traditional values, the Kremlin crafts a narrative that not only attempts to enhance its ontological security but also justifies its actions and shapes public opinion. This construction underscores the complex interplay

between images, narratives, and power dynamics in shaping Russia's identity and its responses to perceived external challenges.

6. Conclusion

In conclusion, the exploration of Russia's state discourse in the context of the Russo-Ukrainian War reveals a multifaceted narrative that transcends conventional security considerations. This thesis has unveiled a nuanced network of factors that collectively illuminate the intricate dynamics underlying Russia's actions.

The research undertaken provides valuable insights into the complexity of Russian identity and its profound implications. Russia's historical connections with Ukraine, especially Crimea, were portrayed as integral to its civilisational heritage. This depiction of territorial expansion as a means of rectifying historical grievances and safeguarding cultural legacy enriches our understanding of Russia's actions beyond immediate material security calculations. Ukraine's alignment with Western values and institutions is framed as an existential threat to Russia's core identity and continuity. This portrayal reflects not only geopolitical dynamics but also the essence of Russia's ontological security.

Collectively, this thesis underscores the complex motivations that underpin Russia's actions. It highlights that Russia's choices are not solely driven by pragmatic realist calculations but are deeply influenced by its perception of identity, history, and continuity amidst perceived external challenges.

These findings illuminate the intricacy of IR and the interplay of identity, historical narratives, and ontological security in shaping state behaviour. By unveiling the layers of Russia's motivations, this research contributes to a deeper comprehension of the Russo-Ukrainian War and, by extension, RFP more broadly. Moving forward, future studies could explore similar dynamics in other prominent states that are characterised by distinctive identities and foreign policy approaches. Undoubtedly, identity remains a pivotal factor in shaping IR and political landscapes. Unravelling its complexities promises insights that illuminate historical, current, and future events.

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